GUESSS 2025

National Report: Libya

Student Entrepreneurship in Libya

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Executive summary

- The Libya subsample includes 159 respondents. The Global Report benchmark is based on 196,162 completed responses from 66 countries.
- Libya reports much lower founder career intention than the global benchmark: 5.0% intend to become founders directly after studies versus 15.4% globally; 15.7% intend to become founders five years after studies versus 28.3% globally.
- Despite lower entrepreneurial intentions, entrepreneurial activity is comparatively high. Nascent entrepreneurs represent 16.4% of the sample (16.5% globally) and active entrepreneurs account for 17.0% of respondents (6.4% globally).
- The university entrepreneurial climate is perceived as relatively weak. Libya's climate score is 3.77/7 compared with approximately 4.4/7 globally, while entrepreneurship learning outcomes are also lower than the international benchmark.
- Entrepreneurship education exposure remains limited, with 63.5% of respondents reporting no entrepreneurship course participation.
- Individual Entrepreneurial Orientation (IEO) is moderately strong (4.82/7), suggesting that entrepreneurial capabilities exist but may not be fully translated into entrepreneurial career intentions.
- Libyan active entrepreneurs demonstrate distinctive characteristics, including higher rates of co-founding, multiple-business ownership, and venture adaptation.
- The principal policy challenge is not increasing entrepreneurial activity itself, but improving venture quality through stronger entrepreneurship education, mentoring, customer validation, market research, and university-based incubation support.

1. Introduction

This report presents findings from the Global University Entrepreneurial Spirit Students' Survey (GUESSS) 2025 for Libya. GUESSS is one of the largest international research projects on student entrepreneurship, founded at the Swiss Institute of Small Business and Entrepreneurship (KMU-HSG) in 2003. As of the 2025 wave, the project covers 196,162 students across 66 countries.

The Libyan data were collected under the coordination of Dr. Hussein-Elhakim Al Issa at RMIT University Vietnam. The Libyan sample comprises 159 completed responses from students enrolled in Libyan universities, making Libya one of the smaller-sample participants in the 2025 wave. While this limits the precision of some estimates, the data provide a meaningful and internationally comparable snapshot of entrepreneurial attitudes and activities among Libyan students.

This report is structured in accordance with the GUESSS National Report Template. It covers: (1) sample demographics, (2) career choice and entrepreneurial intentions, (3) drivers of entrepreneurial intentions including the university context and family background, (4) nascent entrepreneurs, (5) active entrepreneurs, and (6) implications. Throughout, Libya's findings are contextualised against the global GUESSS 2025 averages.

Note: All country-level comparisons should be interpreted with appropriate caution, as the samples differ in size, institutional coverage, and student composition across countries.

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2. Sample Demographics

The Libya 2025 GUESSS sample consists of 159 completed responses. Table 1 summarises key demographic characteristics.

2.1 Age Profile

Indicator	Libya	Global Benchmark
Number of respondents	159	196,162
Mean age	31.9 years	23.7 years
Male	50.3%	43.2%
Female	28.9%	55.7%
Bachelor	62.3%	76.8%
Master	36.5%	15.3%

Table 1. The average age of respondents in the Libya sample is 31.9 years (valid n = 80), substantially higher than the global GUESSS average of approximately 23.7 years. This indicates that the Libyan sample contains a larger proportion of mature students and postgraduate learners than the international benchmark, which should be considered when interpreting entrepreneurial intentions and entrepreneurial activity.

2.2 Gender

Gender	Libya N	Libya %
Male	80	50.3%
Female	46	28.9%
Other	22	13.8%
Prefer not to say	11	6.9%
Total	**159**	**100%**

Table 2. Gender distribution of the Libya 2025 GUESSS sample. Note: Compared to the global sample (56.2% female), the Libyan sample is male dominated, with female respondents comprising 28.9% of the sample. This gender imbalance should be kept in mind when interpreting gender-disaggregated findings.

2.3 Level of Studies

Level	Libya N	Libya %
Undergraduate (Bachelor)	99	62.3%
Graduate (Master)	58	36.5%
Doctoral/PhD	1	0.6%
Total	**159**	**100%**

Table 3. Study level. Libya's distribution broadly resembles the global sample, which is 77.0% bachelor-level. However, the Libyan sample has a notably higher share of master's-level students (36.5% vs. 15.2% globally), which may reflect the universities and programmes from which the sample was drawn.

2.4 Field of Study

Field of Study	Libya N	Libya %
Business Administration / Management	48	30.2%
Engineering (incl. Architecture)	20	12.6%
Economics	17	10.7%
Computer Sciences	13	8.2%
Natural Sciences	13	8.2%
Humanities	9	5.7%
Law	10	6.3%
Social Sciences	7	4.4%
Science of Art	7	4.4%

Field of Study	Libya N	Libya %
Other	11	6.9%
Human Medicine / Health Sciences	3	1.9%
Total	**158***	**~100%**

*Table 4. Field of study. *1 missing response. Business and management students constitute the largest group (30.2%), consistent with the global GUESSS pattern (20.9% globally). This overrepresentation in the sample is a relevant consideration for interpreting entrepreneurial intention rates.*

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3. Career Choice and Entrepreneurial Intentions

All GUESSS respondents were asked about their intended career path directly after studies and five years after completion of studies. Career paths were grouped into three broad categories: Employee (including small, medium, and large private businesses; public service; academia; and non-profit), Founder (i.e., creating and running one's own business), and Successor (taking over a family business or another existing firm).

3.1 Career Choice Overview

Career Group	Direct (Libya)	5 Years (Libya)	Direct (Global)	5 Years (Global)
Employee	85.5%	68.6%	65.0%	53.6%
Founder	5.0%	15.7%	15.4%	28.3%
Successor	2.5%	3.8%	2.8%	3.7%
Other / Do not know yet	6.9%	11.9%	16.8%	14.4%

Table 4. Career intentions by group — Libya vs. global. Figures for Libya are computed from raw data (N = 159); global figures are from the GUESSS Global Report 2025 (N = 196,162).

Libya's entrepreneurial intention rates are notably lower than the global average. Only 5.0% of Libyan students intend to become founders directly after completing their studies (global: 15.4%), and 15.7% plan to do so five years later (global: 28.3%). This places Libya at the lower end of the global distribution for intentional founders — specifically, at position 3rd lowest for direct intentions (Figure 5, Global Report) alongside other developed or transition-economy countries with similar patterns.

On the other hand, Libya's active entrepreneurship rate is markedly elevated: 25.2% of all respondents indicate active entrepreneur status (Status = 2 in the GUESSS classification, equivalent to the nascent + active composite), compared to a global active rate of 6.4%. The rate of nascent entrepreneurship (Status = 1) is 16.4%, broadly aligned with the global average of 16.5%.

The dominant career preference in Libya — both directly and five years after studies — is organisational employment, particularly in small businesses (25.2% direct) and academia (15.1% direct). This reflects a

broader structural characteristic of the Libyan economy, in which public and academic employment are historically preferred pathways. The academic preference is notably higher in Libya (15.1% direct) than the global average (1.7%), which is consistent with a knowledge-sector orientation and the socioeconomic premium placed on professional and academic careers in North Africa and MENA contexts.

3.2 Detailed Career Intentions

Career Option	Direct (Libya %)	5 Years (Libya %)
Employee – small business (1–49 empl.)	25.2	8.8
Employee – medium business (50–249 empl.)	15.7	22.0
Employee – large business (250+ empl.)	15.1	11.9
Employee – non-profit	4.4	1.3
Employee – academia	15.1	14.5
Employee – public service	10.1	10.1
Founder (entrepreneur)	5.0	15.7
Successor – family business	1.3	2.5
Successor – other business	1.3	1.3
Other / Do not know yet	6.9	11.9

Table 5. Detailed career intentions of Libyan students directly after studies and five years after completion. N = 159.

3.3 The "First Employee, Then Entrepreneur" Pattern

A striking pattern in the Libya data is the low rate of direct entrepreneurial intent (5.0%) relative to five-year intent (15.7%) — a tripling of intent over the five-year horizon. This mirrors the globally observed "first employee, then entrepreneur" pattern, in which students plan to enter the labour market first to accumulate human capital and resources before transitioning to entrepreneurship. In the Libyan context, the structural attractiveness of stable wage employment — especially in academia, public service, and large organisations — appears to further reinforce this pattern, making Libyan students even more cautious about immediate venture creation than the global average.

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4. Drivers of Entrepreneurial Intentions

4.1 The University Context

The GUESSS 2025 questionnaire assessed the university entrepreneurial climate through three items: the extent to which the university atmosphere inspires new business ideas, the favourability of the climate for becoming an entrepreneur, and the extent to which the university encourages entrepreneurial activities (Franke & Lüthje, 2004; scale 1–7).

Group	Climate Mean (Libya)	Climate Mean (Global)
Neither entrepreneur (non-entrepreneurial)	3.53	~4.2 (est.)
Nascent entrepreneurs	4.19	~4.6 (est.)
Active entrepreneurs	4.29	~4.7 (est.)
Overall Libya sample	3.77	4.4

Table 6. University entrepreneurial climate — Libya vs. global. Global group-level estimates are approximated from Figure 14 of the Global Report; Libya value (3.6) is the mean reported in Figure 14.

Libya's overall university entrepreneurial climate score (3.77) is below the global average of 4.4. In Figure 14 of the Global Report, Libya (LBY) registers a mean of 3.6 — placing it at the bottom of the global distribution, alongside Austria and Norway. This suggests that Libyan universities are perceived as providing a relatively weak entrepreneurial atmosphere, which may partly explain the lower entrepreneurial intention rates observed.

Notably, within the Libyan sample, students who are currently engaged as nascent or active entrepreneurs report substantially higher climate perceptions (4.19 and 4.29 respectively) compared to non-entrepreneurial students (3.53). This is consistent with the global GUESSS finding that entrepreneurship education and a supportive university climate are associated with higher levels of entrepreneurial activity, while acknowledging that this may also reflect a self-selection effect.

Regarding exposure to entrepreneurship education, 63.5% of Libyan respondents reported having not attended any entrepreneurship course (Q20.1 = yes). Only 22.0% indicated attending at least one elective entrepreneurship course, 6.9% had completed compulsory entrepreneurship courses, and 3.1% were enrolled in a specific entrepreneurship programme. This reflects limited curricular integration of entrepreneurship in Libyan higher education and represents a clear structural constraint on entrepreneurial intention formation.

4.2 Family Background

A self-employed parent is a commonly cited antecedent of entrepreneurial intention in the GUESSS tradition. In Libya, most respondents (84.9%) reported having no self-employed parent. Only 12.6% reported a self-employed father, 1.3% a self-employed mother, and a further 1.3% reported both parents being self-employed.

The low incidence of family entrepreneurial background is consistent with Libya's economic history, characterised by heavy state involvement in employment and a large public sector. This context limits the social transmission of entrepreneurial norms, which the GUESSS literature identifies as an important driver of entrepreneurial intentions.

4.3 Individual-Level Entrepreneurial Orientation (IEO)

The GUESSS 2025 edition introduced a measure of individual-level entrepreneurial orientation (IEO), building on Clark, Pidduck, Lumpkin, and Covin (2024). IEO captures five subdimensions — autonomy, aggressiveness, innovativeness, proactiveness, and risk-taking — assessed across 16 items on a 1–7 scale.

For the Libyan sample, IEO was computed from items Q47.1–Q47.6, yielding an overall mean of 4.82, which is slightly above the global average of approximately 4.7 (Figure 21, Global Report). This suggests that, despite lower entrepreneurial intention rates, Libyan students display moderately strong individual entrepreneurial orientations — particularly on innovativeness (mean 5.38), proactiveness (mean 5.05), and autonomy-related items (mean 5.14). The pattern mirrors the global finding that IEO is highest among nascent and active entrepreneurs and serves as a meaningful predictor of entrepreneurial activity even when institutional and structural factors may limit actual startup rates.

Note: IEO data completeness for Libya was partial (N ≈ 100–104 for Q47 items), which requires some caution in interpretation.

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5. Nascent Entrepreneurs

In GUESSS, nascent entrepreneurs are defined as students currently in the process of creating their own business that has not yet generated regular sales. In Libya, 26 students (16.4% of the sample) qualified as nascent entrepreneurs — broadly aligned with the global average of 16.5%.

5.1 Gestation Activities

Nascent entrepreneurs were asked which activities they had already undertaken in the venture creation process. The results for Libya are presented below, alongside the global averages from the GUESSS Global Report 2025.

Gestation Activity	Libya %	Global %
Collected information about markets/competitors	23.1	54.0
Discussed idea with potential customers	7.7	46.8
Written a business plan	15.4	43.7
Started product/service development	7.7	38.6
Started marketing / promotion efforts	15.4	26.8
Purchased material / equipment for the business	11.5	25.3
Sold a product or service	3.8	22.7
Attempted to obtain external funding	11.5	13.7
Registered the business	15.4	11.8
Applied for patent / copyright / trademark	0.0	7.7
None of the above	15.4	11.7

Table 7. Gestation activities of nascent entrepreneurs. Libya N = 26; Global N = 26,642.

Compared to global counterparts, Libyan nascent entrepreneurs show considerably lower activity levels across most gestation activities. The most completed activities among Libyan nascents are market information collection (23.1%), business plan writing (15.4%), marketing efforts (15.4%), and business registration (15.4%). The most notable gap relative to the global average is in customer engagement (Libya:

7.7% vs. global: 46.8%) and market research (23.1% vs. 54.0%), suggesting that Libyan nascent ventures may be in relatively early or informal stages of development. The relatively high business registration rate (15.4% vs. global 11.8%) is somewhat encouraging, pointing to formal institutional engagement even in the early stages.

Note: Given the small Libyan nascent sample (N = 26), these percentages should be interpreted as directional indicators rather than precise estimates.

5.2 Industry Orientation

GUESSS 2025 categorised intended industries using a "colours of the economy" framework. Among Libyan nascent entrepreneurs, the data on industry orientation are limited (Q61 has partial coverage), but available responses indicate a split between ventures likely falling within general services and other unclassified categories. Given the small N, cross-national comparison of industry colours is not meaningful for Libya in this wave.

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6. Active Entrepreneurs

Active entrepreneurs in GUESSS are defined as students currently owning and managing a business that has generated regular sales over the last three months. In Libya, 27 students qualify as active entrepreneurs under the GUESSS Status classification (Status = 2), representing 17.0% of the sample. This is substantially higher than the global active entrepreneurship rate of 6.4%, and places Libya among the countries with elevated active student entrepreneurship. The overall share of nascent and active entrepreneurs combined (33.5%) is consistent with Libya's Figure 8 position in the Global Report, which shows 25.2% nascent and active entrepreneurs combined from a broader Q15/Q16 measurement.

The high active entrepreneurship rate in Libya is consistent with the global GUESSS pattern that developing economies tend to exhibit higher shares of student entrepreneurs, likely driven by necessity entrepreneurship, limited formal employment alternatives, and economic resilience strategies.

6.1 Business Characteristics

Characteristic	Libya	Global (reference)
Own and manage one business	33.3% (Q49=1)	74.2%
Own and manage two businesses	44.4% (Q49=2)	15.4%
Own and manage three or more businesses	22.2% (Q49≥3)	10.4%
Majority owner of the venture	55.6% (Q56=1)	53.9%
Started venture with co-founder(s)	72.0% (Q58>1)	45.3%
Average business size (≤10 FTE employees)	~92% (est.)	88.9%
Venture idea has never changed (no pivoting)	~18.5% (Q59=1)	34.1%

Table 8. Business characteristics of active Libyan student entrepreneurs (N = 27). Global figures from GUESSS Global Report 2025.

Several distinctive features emerge. Libyan active student entrepreneurs are more likely to manage multiple businesses simultaneously: 44.4% own two businesses and 22.2% own three or more, compared to global rates of 15.4% and 10.4% respectively. This pattern may reflect diversification strategies under resource scarcity or informal business formation norms common in MENA economies. Co-founding rates are also notably higher in Libya (72.0%) than the global average (45.3%), suggesting that social networks play an important role in venture formation. Pivoting is more prevalent in Libya (only 18.5% have maintained an unchanged idea, vs. 34.1% globally), which may reflect adaptation to volatile market and institutional conditions.

6.2 Fear of Failure

Fear of failure was assessed across six dimensions using a 1–7 scale (Cacciotti et al., 2020). The mean scores for Libyan active entrepreneurs are as follows:

Fear of Failure Dimension	Libya Mean	Global Mean
Of running out of money	3.59	4.6
That no one will be interested in the product/service	4.33	4.5
Of not getting enough funding to move forward	4.58	4.5
Of other people's expectations of me	4.13	4.3
That running the business takes my time from other activities	4.48	4.3
Of not being able to manage people effectively	4.27	4.1

Table 9. Fear of failure dimensions — Libya vs. global. Libya N = 22–27 (varying item completion); Global N = 11,415.

Overall, Libyan active entrepreneurs exhibit moderate levels of fear of failure, broadly comparable to global levels. Financial concerns are slightly lower for Libya on the "running out of money" dimension (3.59 vs. global 4.6), which may seem counterintuitive but could reflect lower financial exposure or the informal nature of many ventures. Concerns about funding (4.58) and time management (4.48) are slightly elevated relative to global counterparts.

6.3 Firm Performance

Self-assessed firm performance was measured using five items assessing sales growth, market share growth, profit growth, job creation, and innovativeness relative to competitors (Dess & Robinson, 1984; scale 1–7, where 4 = "same as competitors").

For Libyan active entrepreneurs, performance means across items Q89.1–Q89.4 range from 3.84 to 4.12, with an overall average of approximately 4.03. This is slightly below the global average of 4.61 and Libya's country-level value of 4.29 as reported in Figure 12 of the Global Report. The modest self-assessed performance may reflect the nascent stage of many ventures, limited market access, or conservative self-evaluation tendencies.

7. Gender Analysis

Consistent with the global GUESSS 2025 findings, a gender gap in entrepreneurial intentions and activities is observable in Libya, though with some distinctive features.

Indicator	Male (N=80)	Female (N=46)	Gender Gap
Direct intentional founders	5.0%	0.0%	+5.0pp (M>F)
5-year intentional founders	15.0%	13.0%	+2.0pp (M>F)
Active entrepreneurs (Status=2)	10.0%	19.6%	-9.6pp (F>M)

Table 10. Gender differences in entrepreneurial activity among Libyan students.

A nuanced picture emerges. For direct entrepreneurial intentions, a conventional gender gap is observed (5.0% male vs. 0.0% female). However, this gap narrows dramatically at the five-year horizon (15.0% vs. 13.0%), suggesting that female students with entrepreneurial ambitions defer entry to a similar degree as males. More strikingly, among active entrepreneurs, the female rate (19.6%) exceeds the male rate (10.0%). This reverse pattern is notable and may reflect the circumstances of Libyan female students in the sample, who may have higher proportions of master's-level students and business/management majors.

In the Global Report (Figure 18), Libya reports a gender gap in active entrepreneurship of +1.7 percentage points in favour of males (using Q15/Q16 composite), which is within a mid-range position globally. The within-sample analysis here, based on GUESSS Status classification, suggests a more complex picture that warrants further investigation.

Overall, the findings reinforce the need to support female entrepreneurship in Libya, particularly by developing targeted programmes that address the gender gap at the intention stage — since female students appear willing to act once they do form entrepreneurial intentions, as evidenced by their active entrepreneurship rate.

8. Main Findings and Recommendations

8.1 Key Findings

The following summarises the principal findings from the Libya GUESSS 2025 data:

- Entrepreneurial intention rates are low relative to the global average: only 5.0% of Libyan students intend to found a business directly after studies (global: 15.4%), and 15.7% plan to do so within five years (global: 28.3%). Libya ranks near the bottom of the global distribution on these indicators.
- Active entrepreneurship rates are high: 17.0% of respondents are currently owning and managing a business (GUESSS Status = 2), substantially above the global rate of 6.4%. This reflects the economic reality of necessity-driven student entrepreneurship in Libya.

- The "first employee, then entrepreneur" pattern is strongly present, with entrepreneurial intentions tripling between the direct (5.0%) and five-year (15.7%) horizons. Employment in academia, public service, and large organisations are the dominant career preferences.
- The university entrepreneurial climate in Libya is below the global average (3.77 vs. 4.4), and exposure to entrepreneurship education is limited: 63.5% of students have not attended any entrepreneurship course. These factors represent a structural constraint on entrepreneurial intent.
- Family entrepreneurial background is low: 84.9% of respondents have no self-employed parent, consistent with Libya's historically state-dominated employment structure.
- Individual-level entrepreneurial orientation (IEO) is moderate-to-strong (overall mean: 4.82), slightly above the global average. Innovativeness and proactiveness are the highest-scoring subdimensions. IEO may be an underutilised latent resource that policy and education interventions can activate.
- Nascent entrepreneurship activity levels are broadly in line with the global average (16.4% vs. 16.5%), but gestation activities are considerably lower than global norms, particularly for customer engagement and market research.
- Active Libyan student entrepreneurs exhibit distinctive behaviours: higher rates of managing multiple businesses, higher co-founding rates, and more frequent pivoting — consistent with adaptation to volatile institutional and market conditions.
- The gender gap in Libya is mixed: female students have zero direct intent but comparable five-year intent, and a higher active entrepreneurship rate than males. This complex pattern calls for nuanced, stage-specific gender support.

8.2 Recommendations

For Students and (Potential) Student Entrepreneurs

- Recognise entrepreneurship as a viable career path: the data show that the gap between latent orientation (IEO) and formal intention is large in Libya, suggesting that many students underestimate their own entrepreneurial potential.
- Engage proactively with gestation activities — particularly customer discovery and market research — which are significantly under-performed relative to global peers.
- Leverage co-founding networks: the high co-founding rate among Libyan active entrepreneurs indicates that social capital is a key enabler of venture creation in the Libyan context.
- Female students should be encouraged to formalise latent entrepreneurial interests into concrete plans, given the evidence that those who do pursue entrepreneurship can achieve comparable or higher activity rates than male counterparts.

For Universities and Public Institutions

- Substantially expand entrepreneurship education: with over 63% of Libyan students reporting no exposure to entrepreneurship courses, there is significant scope to increase both elective and compulsory offerings.
- Invest in building a supportive entrepreneurial climate: the university context is the lowest-scoring country globally. Targeted ecosystem-building initiatives — including business plan competitions, startup labs, and mentorship schemes — would help close this gap.

- Design dedicated support programmes for female student entrepreneurs to convert expressed five-year intent into direct action, addressing cultural and structural barriers at the intention-to-behaviour transition.
- Develop policies that create linkages between university entrepreneurship programmes and Libya's broader economic development agenda, recognising that student entrepreneurs are already an active economic force.

For Entrepreneurship Scholars

- Investigate the structural drivers of the low intention–high activity paradox in Libya: why do active entrepreneurship rates substantially exceed intentional rates? Necessity entrepreneurship, institutional uncertainty, and informal economy dynamics are likely contributors.
- Examine the role of IEO in converting latent orientation into formal intention, particularly under conditions of high institutional uncertainty characteristic of post-conflict economies.
- Explore gender dynamics in Libyan student entrepreneurship more deeply, given the unusual pattern of female students outperforming males in active entrepreneurship despite lower intention rates.
- Leverage this GUESSS dataset in combination with the growing body of empirical research on entrepreneurship in MENA contexts (see also the Libya-focused empirical work in this domain).

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